

In Midterms,
G.O.P. Mired
With Trump

Strategizing to Outrun
Unpopular Policies

This article is by Annie Karni, Reid J. Epstein and Luke Broadwater.

WASHINGTON — In the White House Rose Garden last week, President Trump gathered some of the most politically endangered House Republicans for a dinner where he promised to make himself the face of the party’s uphill battle to keep control of Congress. He was with them “100 percent — all the way until November,” Mr. Trump told the roughly two dozen lawmakers as they dined on prime aged beef burgers at tables adorned with bouquets of yellow roses. The president said he would travel to 35 key districts “to see if we can get everyone elected.”

The scene encapsulated the box that G.O.P. lawmakers have found themselves in as they stare down a bleak political environment. They cannot afford to snub Mr. Trump, needing help from his enormous financial reserves and strong turnout from his base to win their campaigns. But they also do not want the election to be a referendum on the president, whose popularity is at a record low. And so far, he has shown little appetite for focusing on anyone’s political needs besides his own.

Two months before the midterm elections, Mr. Trump and the Republicans who have long tied their political fortunes to him appear to be at cross-purposes as the party struggles to keep the House and Senate in G.O.P. hands.

As Republicans work to distance themselves from the president’s unpopular decisions, Mr. Trump is headlining a splashy convention in Dallas this week and has said that voters should “pretend, please, that I’m on the ballot.” As the candidates work to show they are focused on the con-

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Big A.I. Payout
Sets Publishers
Against Authors

By NEIL VIGDOR

The sum is gargantuan: \$1.5 billion. But as thousands of authors wait for their cut of the largest copyright settlement in U.S. history, from Anthropic, the tech giant that used pirated books to train its artificial intelligence chatbot, some are accusing the publishers of their books of trying to squeeze them out of a percentage of the payout.

The haggling is coming into plain view as a settlement administrator attempts to clear up who owns the rights to some of the more than 482,000 books covered by the agreement in the class-action case, which was approved in July by a judge in the U.S. District Court in the Northern District of California.

For many of those titles, ownership is undisputed, but on repeated occasions, authors and publishers have staked competing claims with the settlement administrator, which began recently informing them of those discrepancies, said Mary Rasenberger, chief executive of the Authors Guild, a professional association that says it has more than 18,000 members.

In an interview, Rasenberger Continued on Page A11



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A Day to Celebrate Caribbean Culture

Brooklyn’s West Indian American Day Parade on Monday featured painted revelers dancing to reggae and sampling treats. But many felt the absence of Haitians after a crackdown. Page A16.

Saving an Arm and a Leg on Gas: No Lead Foot

By POOJA SALHOTRA

When a traffic light turns green, Dan Kroushl is unlikely to be the first driver out of the gate. He won’t floor the gas pedal, and he never drives over the speed limit. Instead, he eases forward by lightly pressing the accelerator, and the moment he sees a yellow light, he gently taps the brakes. These techniques and others make Mr. Kroushl, 61, a so-called hypermiler, a driver who squeez-

Hypermilers Hail Light
Touch at the Wheel

es as many miles as possible out of each gallon of gas. And after a summer of soaring gas prices driven by the war in Iran, hypermilers like Mr. Kroushl say their strategies can help drivers who are feeling pinched at the pump make the most of every gallon. “People think when they are

pumping gas: I can’t do anything about it,” Bradlee Fons, 74, a fellow hypermiler, said of the increased gas prices. “I tell them, ‘You’re in total control.’ People can control their fuel costs.” Hypermilers mostly aim to maximize fuel efficiency by driving smoothly, without hard stops or starts. But sometimes they employ more extreme measures, like not using air conditioning or removing a vehicle’s interior door panels to reduce its weight. Continued on Page A11



TODD KOROL FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Taking the Sweetness Out of Honey

This year, rain and President Trump’s increased tariffs have hit an Alberta specialty hard. Page A4.

He Saw a Nimbler Army.
Hegseth Wanted Him Out.

A Commander’s Lifetime of Experience and
Powerful Allies Couldn’t Save Him

By ADAM ENTOUS and GREG JAFFE

WASHINGTON — Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth decided in early 2025 to spike Gen. Christopher T. Donahue’s nomination to be the top U.S. military officer in Europe. Mr. Hegseth believed that President Trump wanted heads to roll for the deaths of 13 U.S. service members in a suicide bombing at the Kabul airport during the U.S. withdrawal from Afghanistan in 2021. General Donahue was not responsible for security at the bombing site. But he was a top commander at the airport, and so Mr. Hegseth decided he needed to go.

It fell to Joe Kasper, Mr. Hegseth’s chief of staff, to try to convince him that he was wrong. Mr. Kasper asked a senior Pentagon official to prepare a card with a half-dozen bullet points laying out the facts in General Donahue’s defense, current and former officials said. He took it with him in March of last year as he and Mr. Hegseth sped through traffic to the White House for a press event. For those few minutes in the car, Mr. Kasper knew he would have his boss’s undivided attention. Sirens were blaring. He handed Mr. Hegseth the card. These were the facts of General Donahue’s three-decade career: He had seen more combat in his

20-plus deployments than just about any other officer in the U.S. military. A star in the clandestine world of special forces, he had spent years in the shadows hunting terrorist leaders. And then as the world and warfare changed, he changed with it. He had played a central role in the U.S. military’s efforts to help Ukraine hold off a much larger Russian force, a job that inspired his vision for a new kind of combat that married divebombing drones, robotics and artificial intelligence. Now his fate lay in the hands of Mr. Hegseth, a former Fox News host who had two deployments as an Army officer to Iraq and Af-

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ALLISON JOYCE/A.F.P. VIA GETTY IMAGES

Gen. Christopher T. Donahue fell prey to a leadership purge.

Peru’s Embrace
Of China Draws
Heat From U.S.

By GENEVIEVE GLATSKY

LIMA, Peru — Peru’s ambassador in Washington, Luis Miguel Castilla, received a stern phone call in 2015 from the State Department, after U.S. officials learned that a Chinese firm would finance a sprawling new Pacific Coast port project. Why, they asked, was Peru handing Beijing a strategic foothold in South America? Mr. Castilla’s answer was blunt: Western investors had already passed. The port’s Peruvian private sector promoters “came to knock on doors here and in Europe, and no one opened the door,” Mr. Castilla said. “So, any space left behind is space that someone else takes.” Today, the \$1.3 billion Chinese-backed megaport in Chancay, north of Lima, the capital, has become the most visible symbol of China’s expanding economic presence in Peru. It is also a key reason the country, which Secretary of State Marco Rubio is planning to visit this week, has emerged as a testing ground for one of President Trump’s core objectives in Latin America: rolling back Beijing’s influence in the Western Hemisphere. Senior administration officials have warned while offering no evidence that Chinese-financed projects threaten Peru’s sovereignty and, in the case of the port, could give Beijing a military foothold. But in Peru, Washington’s pressure collides with a stubborn reality: China has become Peru’s largest trading partner and a major investor in mining, energy and infrastructure — a relationship that Continued on Page A6

Far-Right Win
Sends Shudder
Past Germany

By MARK LANDLER

PARIS — When a far-right party won a landslide victory on Sunday in a small state in eastern Germany, its reverberations could be felt from Downing Street in London to the Elysée Palace in Paris. Rarely has the result of a regional election been viewed with such portent for the fate of democracy in Europe. This wasn’t just any European country; it was Germany, a country that has relentlessly isolated far-right political parties since the calamity of Nazism. And it wasn’t just a strange outlier, but rather the latest step in a steady, decade-long march that has brought the far right ever closer to the fulcrum of power in Europe. With elections scheduled across Europe next year, the striking success of the party, Alternative for Germany, could be a harbinger of further far-right victories, according to analysts, as well as a template for how they can be engineered. Its populist, anti-immigrant message echoes those of nationalist leaders in Britain, France, Italy and Spain, all countries where voters harbor many of the same grievances as those in Germany. French voters will elect a new president next spring. An election is due in Spain by August, and in Italy by the end of next year. Far-right candidates are surging in all of them, threatening incumbents blamed for systemic problems with their countries’ economies. “Developed Europe is going Continued on Page A8

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Chatty About Gilt, Not War

As the Iran conflict grinds on, President Trump finds reprieve by talking about the minutiae of his pet construction projects in Washington. PAGE A10

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It’s Getting Dark Online

China has long endeavored to make the dominant mood of the country’s internet upbeat and positive. But that’s not what young people are posting. PAGE B1

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‘Zombie Churches’ Come Alive

Many houses of worship in Europe have been abandoned, but some of them have found new life as health care centers or spaces for the arts. PAGE C1

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Bringing Genetics to Heel

Scientists edited canine genes to create a pair of hypoallergenic beagles, but it is still a long way from the laboratory to the laps of pet owners. PAGE D1

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David French

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